

Plants for winter beds

Days may be cold and dark, but with a selection of winter flowers, berries, stems, and leaves, gardens can continue to look stunning.

Evergreens are the mainstay of the winter garden, but the colorful stems of birch, bamboo, and twig dogwoods can upstage even the most dramatic conifer. Flowers are at a premium at this time of year, but this makes those that do face the cold all the more charismatic. Some plants, including Oregon grapeholly, sweet box, and witch hazel also offer scent into the bargain. Combine these beauties with the seedheads of summer flowers and grasses, and plants with dangling catkins, such as silk-tassel bush.



PERENNIAL SMALL

Arum italicum

ITALIAN ARUM The dark green arrow-shaped fall leaves of this perennial persist in winter in mild areas and are joined by white or yellow petal-like spring spathes. 'Marmoratum' has cream-patterned leaves. May be invasive.

↑12in (30cm) ↔6in (15cm)

☀️ ⚠️ Z5–9



TREE LARGE

Betula utilis var. *jacquemontii*

HIMALAYAN BIRCH Brightening up winter beds with its white trunk and stems, this deciduous tree can be used to create small woodlands. The diamond-shaped, dark green leaves, which turn yellow in fall, unfurl in spring after yellow catkins appear.

↑60ft (18m) ↔30ft (10m)

☀️ ☀️ ☀️ Z4–7



SHRUB MEDIUM

Abeliophyllum distichum

WHITE FORSYTHIA Plant this deciduous shrub in a sheltered spot where hard frosts will not damage the fragrant, star-shaped, pink-tinged white flowers, which appear on bare stems in late winter. The dark green leaves appear later in spring.

↑↔5ft (1.5m)

☀️ ☀️ Z5–8



PERENNIAL SMALL

Ajuga reptans

BUGLEWEED The purple-leaved form of this aggressive evergreen ground-cover perennial forms mats of foliage interest in winter beds. It has blue spring-flower spikes. 'Atropurpurea' (above) has bronze-tinted leaves. Considered invasive in some areas.

↑6in (15cm) ↔3ft (1m)

☀️ ☀️ ☀️ Z3–9



PERENNIAL MEDIUM

Carex flagellifera

WEeping BROWN SEDGE This evergreen sedge has tufts of reddish brown leaves and late summer spikes of light brown flowers, followed by red-brown seedheads. Plant it at the front of a border in free-draining soil in areas of hard frosts.

↑32in (80cm) ↔24in (60cm) or more

☀️ ☀️ ☀️ Z7–10



PERENNIAL MEDIUM

Carex 'Ice Dance'

SEDGE Plant this decorative evergreen, perennial sedge at the front of a sunny or part-shaded bed. It produces mounds of grasslike, creamy edged green leaves and small white flowers in spring. Plant in mass or in woodland garden.

↑24in (60cm) ↔30in (75cm)

☀️ ☀️ ☀️ Z5–9



SHRUB LARGE

Chimonanthus praecox

WINTERSWEET This large deciduous shrub produces simple, lance-shaped midgreen leaves. In winter, bowl-shaped, fragrant, many-petalled sulfur-yellow flowers appear. These are followed by cylindrical or urn-shaped seed capsules.

↑12ft (4m) ↔10ft (3m)

☀️ ☀️ Z7–9



CLIMBER MEDIUM

Clematis cirrhosa

EARLY VIRGIN'S-BOWER Plant this evergreen climber with toothed, green leaves on a sheltered surface to protect its bell-shaped, red-spotted cream late winter to early spring flowers. Shade the roots. 'Freckles' has speckled, creamy pink flowers.

↑10ft (3m)

☀️ ☀️ ☀️ Z7–11



CLIMBER LARGE

Clematis tangutica

GOLDEN CLEMATIS The lantern-shaped yellow flowers of this vigorous deciduous clematis are followed by fluffy silvery seedheads that provide winter interest at the back of a bed. Cut stems to the ground in late winter; plant with the roots in shade.

↑20ft (6m)

☀️ ☀️ Z4–9



SHRUB LARGE

Cornus alba

TATARIAN DOGWOOD Grow this deciduous shrub in a bed where its colorful display of bright red young shoots will be most effective. For the best color, cut down old stems in late winter to spur new growth, and plant in moist soil.

↑↔10ft (3m)

☀️ ☀️ Z2–7